



1825 Long corset (reconstructed) to support the bust and cover the hips, laced at the back



1875 Corset (back view) cut shorter at the back, to accommodate a bustle



1895–1900 Corset (back view), laced at the back through metal eyelets



1910 Corset with suspender straps



1960s Girdle with sprigged floral print and suspender straps



1996 Bustier by Rigby and Peller, London, decorated with black lace

SUPPORTING SKIRTS

After the advent of the farthingale in the mid-16th century came a succession of skirt shapes and styles for women. These changing silhouettes were achieved with the support of hooped under-structures, such as panniers and crinolines, or with layer upon layer of padded and stiffened petticoats. Hooped supports had the advantage of being much lighter and, as construction technologies advanced, held larger and larger skirts, which were at their widest during the 1860s.

Bum roll (replica)



Farthingale (replica)

c.1550 Farthingales and bum rolls were worn under skirts from 1545 to the 1620s. Bum rolls, fastened around the waist and tied at the front, gave added volume at the hips.

1750s This robe à la française would have been worn over panniers or hoops, to support the wide skirts.



Fabric draped over back

Hoops worn over hips



Panniers



Crinoline

Skirts reached their widest in the 1860s



1860 The cage crinoline, made from hoops of steel, was much lighter than the layers of petticoats that preceded it.



Crinolette

Bustled overskirt



1872–74 Crinolettes, or half-crinolines, were made from half-hoops of steel. They acted as bustles, a fashion that first gained popularity in the early 1870s.